

challenging. My father couldn't see me for the first 11 months. When everybody was leaving the city, he was trying to get into the city to see his son. The hospital where I was born was evacuated and bombed just a couple of days later," Dzumhur told *Sportstar* in an exclusive interaction.

"I started playing tennis when I was five and a half years old. My first memory of playing tennis is from a high school fitness place where there wasn't even a tennis court. Most of the courts in Sarajevo were destroyed," he added.

Dzumhur learned the basics of the sport from his father, Nerfid, who had started a tennis school in 1994 at Zetra Olympic Hall, a venue located near the same hospital where Dzumhur was born.

While growing up, tennis wasn't the only thing in young Dzumhur's life. He even acted in two movies — *Grbavica* (2006), as a background actor, and *Morderischer Frieden* (2007), in which he played a major role as Durcan.

"A few of the classes from my primary school were called for auditions. I went there and made it through two rounds to get cast for *Grbavica*, which wasn't a big project. A couple of months after that, I got called for another audition for *Morderischer Frieden*. I went there without any expectations. Later, I got a call asking if I wanted to do the movie. I signed the contract," recalls Dzumhur. "So my first earned money was not from tennis, but from movies. As a 14-year-old, it was a big amount for me. After that, I was called for two more movies in Bosnia but tennis became my priority. Who knows, maybe after tennis, this is something I can do."

Despite limited facilities and infrastructure back home, Dzumhur continued to work hard on his game. He won his maiden Tour-level title in St Petersburg in 2017. After his third title in Antalya in 2018, he achieved a career-high ranking of 23.

He had his struggles with form after 2018, but perhaps the biggest setback came after his first-round loss to Fernando Verdasco in the



French Open qualifiers. "Definitely, it was the hardest part of my career. Just after the match, I had to go to hospital due to a bad stomach ache," he said. The Bosnian was diagnosed with acute pancreatitis. "I was in hospital for one month. I was recovering for another month. It was a hard period, not just in tennis but in life in general. I was really not sure what was going to happen with my tennis career. I didn't know if I was going to continue," he added.

But Dzumhur found a second wind.

In August 2022, he had sunk to 243 in the ATP rankings. He kept pushing to get better and after a sensational 2024 season, during which he won six titles on the ATP Challenger Tour, he was back inside the top 100. This resurgence set the stage for renewed confidence on the biggest platforms.

Reflecting on this year's French Open match against Alcaraz, Dzumhur said, "When I face Carlos, I have to play very offensively. I have to always be there on the ball, and I cannot let him be too offensive because once he gets the time, he's so dangerous and there is nothing you can do. So, playing very offensive tennis is probably what gives me a

**Test of mettle:** Facing Alcaraz isn't easy. Challenging him is even more difficult. But for Dzumhur, the Spaniard wasn't the first curveball life had thrown at him. Not even the biggest. PICS: GETTY IMAGES

lot of chances against him. Perhaps playing with that mindset against other players will help me."

Dzumhur has returned to India for the first time since he played the Chennai Open, an ATP 250 event, in 2017.

The Bosnian is the marquee player for the Yash Mumbai Smashers side in the seventh season of the Tennis Premier League (TPL), a franchise-based competition being held in Ahmedabad from December 9 to 14.

"It's very important to have these exhibition tournaments. Sometimes, tennis events can be boring for those watching from the stands. For us, playing five hours might be great but it is very hard for the spectators. TPL's format is fast and dynamic. Many people are moving to pickleball and padel. These kinds of tournaments are crucial to maintain tennis' popularity," Dzumhur signed off.